SALESFORCE ADMIN COURSE • EPISODE 37

Record-Level Security & Sharing Architecture

Mastering Salesforce Record Access: Organization-Wide Defaults (OWD), Role Hierarchy, Sharing Rules, Public Groups, Manual Sharing, Collaborative Teams, and Enterprise Territory Architecture.

- 🔑 Core Question: "Which records can this user access?"
- 🛡️ OWD: The Restrictive Baseline Starting Point
- 🏢 Role Hierarchy: Opening Access Vertically
- 🤝 Sharing Rules: Opening Access Horizontally
- ⚡ Manual Sharing & Collaborative Record Teams
- 🧪 5-Step Hands-On Demonstration on Opportunity

Created by Sachin • Salesforce Certified Administrator Series • Duration: ~28–32 Mins

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1. Introduction: The Final Major Security Layer

Over the preceding episodes, we unlocked the building through Organization-Level Security, mastered the table permissions through **Object-Level Security** (CRUD), and secured the columns through **Field-Level Security** (FLS).

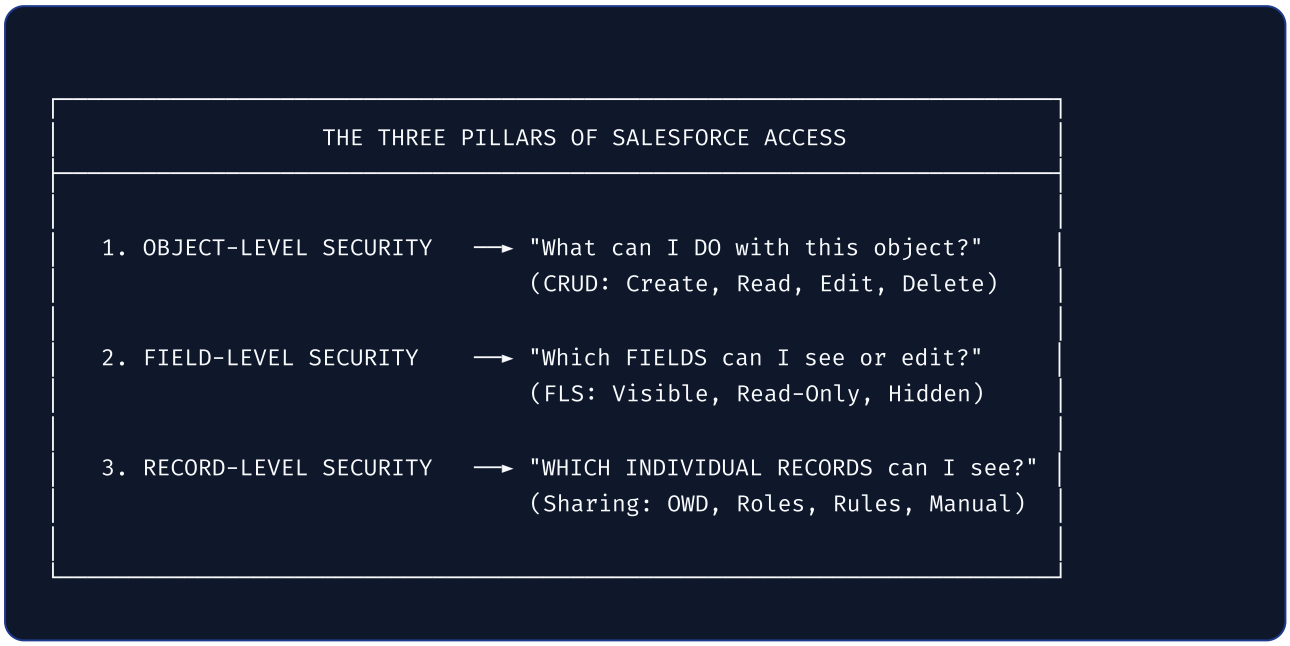
Now we reach the deepest, most dynamic, and most heavily tested layer of Salesforce security: **Record-Level Security**.

> *"Suppose Rahul and Priya both have Read, Create, and Edit access to the Opportunity object. Does that mean they can automatically see every Opportunity record created in the company? Absolutely not!"*

Object access determines *capability*; Record-Level Security determines *visibility*. Without record access, an authorized user cannot see or touch individual records!

2. What is Record-Level Security?

Record-Level Security governs **which specific records (rows) a user can access** within an object they already have permission to view.



3. Record Ownership (The Fundamental Anchor)

Every Salesforce record has an assigned **Owner** (a specific User or, for supported objects, a Queue). Record ownership provides automatic full access to that record (View, Edit, Delete, Transfer, and Share), subject to profile CRUD permissions.

Record ownership is the critical anchor upon which:

- **Organization-Wide Defaults (OWD)** evaluate non-owner baseline access.
- **Role Hierarchy** rolls access upward to managers.
- **Owner-Based Sharing Rules** identify source records to share laterally.

4. Organization-Wide Defaults (OWD)

Organization-Wide Defaults (OWD) define the **baseline level of access** that users have to records they do not own.

> **The Golden Architectural Principle: Least Privilege**
> Salesforce architecture always starts by locking down OWD to the *most restrictive baseline* required by business policy (usually **Private**), and then selectively opening access upward and outward using sharing tools.

Standard OWD Options

🔒 Private

Only the record owner and users above them in the Role Hierarchy can access records. Other users have zero access unless shared.

👁️ Public Read Only

All users can view every record of this object, but only the owner (and those above in the hierarchy) can edit or delete them.

🖍️ Public Read/Write

All users can view and edit any record across the entire org, regardless of ownership (deleting still requires ownership or higher privileges).

🔗 Controlled by Parent

Child record access in Master-Detail relationships is entirely dictated by the user's access to the parent master record.

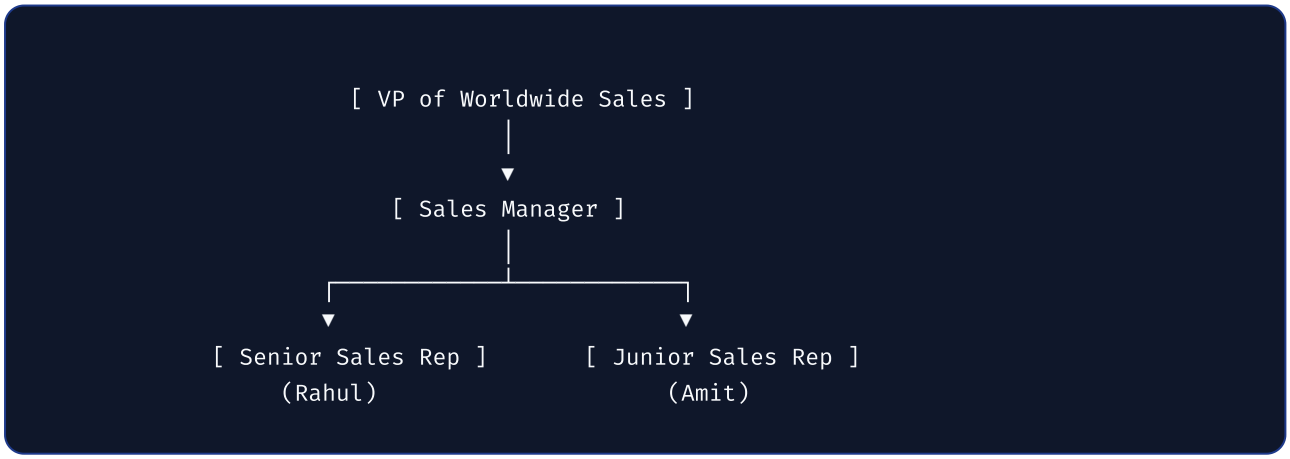
Internal vs. External Sharing Defaults

If your organization utilizes **Experience Cloud (Portals/Communities)**, Salesforce separates OWD into two columns:

- **Default Internal Access:** Governs employees and internal CRM users.
- **Default External Access:** Governs Community users, customers, and partner portal users. (Must always be equal to or more restrictive than internal access).

5. Role Hierarchy: Upward Visibility

The **Role Hierarchy** opens record access **vertically upward**. A user at a higher level in the hierarchy automatically inherits the same level of access to records owned by or shared with users below them in the tree.



If Rahul owns an Opportunity with OWD set to *Private*:

- **Amit (Peer):** No Access ❌ (Horizontal sharing is closed by default).
- **Sales Manager (Direct Manager):** Inherits Access ✅ (Can view and edit Rahul's record).
- **VP of Worldwide Sales (Executive):** Inherits Access ✅ (Flows all the way to the top).

Crucial Best Practice: Role Hierarchy ≠ Company HR Org Chart
The Role Hierarchy is designed solely for **data access and reporting rollup**. You should never replicate your HR hierarchy 1:1 if multiple managers have identical data access requirements!

6. Role vs. Profile: The Essential Distinction

Administrators must never confuse Roles with Profiles:

ATTRIBUTE	PROFILE	ROLE
Primary Question	**"What can the user do?"**	**"Which records can the user see?"**
Access Level Governed	Object Permissions (CRUD), FLS, System Permissions, Page Layouts, Login Hours.	Record-Level Sharing via the Role Hierarchy and Sharing Rules.
Assignment Requirement	**Mandatory** (Every user must have exactly 1 Profile).	**Optional** (A user can exist with no assigned Role).
Grants CRUD?	YES — Dictates whether you can Create, Read, Edit, Delete.	NO — Never grants object CRUD rights!

7. Sharing Rules: Lateral / Horizontal Access

When users across different branches of the Role Hierarchy need to collaborate (e.g., Sales Users sharing Opportunities with the Support Team or Marketing Team), Role Hierarchy cannot solve the problem.

Sharing Rules are automatic exceptions to OWD that open access laterally:

👤 1. Owner-Based Sharing Rules

Shares records based on **who owns them**.
Example: "All Opportunities owned by users in the `North America Sales` role are shared with the `Support Team` Public Group."

🎯 2. Criteria-Based Sharing Rules

Shares records based on **record field values**, regardless of who owns the record.
Example: "All Opportunities where `Amount > $100,000` are shared with `Executive Management`."

Sharing Rule Targets:
Records can be shared with: **Public Groups**, **Roles**, and **Roles and Internal Subordinates** with either *Read Only* or *Read/Write* access.

8. Manual Sharing

When an individual user needs to share a single, specific record on a one-off basis with a peer, creating an automated sharing rule is unnecessary overkill.

Manual Sharing allows the record owner, users above them in the hierarchy, or administrators to click the **Sharing** button on a record page and directly share it with individual Users, Public Groups, or Roles.

- Can grant **Read Only** or **Read/Write** access.
- Can be revoked at any time by the owner or admin.
- *Note:* If record ownership changes, manual shares are automatically cleared!

9. Collaborative Mechanisms: Teams, Territories & Queues

👥 Collaborative Teams

Account Teams, **Opportunity Teams**, and **Case Teams** allow record owners to assemble a multi-user team with tailored access (Read Only or Read/Write) to collaborate on deals or accounts.

🗺️ Territory Management

Enterprise Territory Management shares Accounts and Opportunities based on geographic, industry, or revenue-based territory models rather than traditional owner hierarchies.

📬 Queues

Queues act as group owners for supported objects (Cases, Leads, custom objects). All queue members inherit record access to manage shared workloads until assigned to individuals.

10. The Complete Record-Level Security Funnel

Salesforce evaluates record-level access like a layered funnel—starting completely closed at OWD and expanding access outward:



11. Hands-On Practical Demonstration (5 Progressive Steps)

Follow these practical steps to build and verify the entire record security funnel in your developer org using the standard `Opportunity` object:

STEP 01 — **Set Opportunity OWD to Private**

```
Setup ➔ Sharing Settings ➔ Edit Sharing Settings
```

Locate **Opportunity** in the Sharing Settings table. Set **Default Internal Access** to **Private**. Click **Save**. (Salesforce will recalibrate sharing in the background).

STEP 02

Create Test Opportunity & Verify Private Lockdown

```
Log in as Rahul → Opportunities → New → Create "ABC Opportunity"
```

Rahul creates and owns `ABC Opportunity`. Now log in as **Priya** (a peer sales user with full Opportunity CRUD). Search for `ABC Opportunity`.

Result: Priya **cannot see or search** Rahul's opportunity! Even though she has Object CRUD rights, the Private OWD blocks her access.

STEP 03

Configure Role Hierarchy & Test Upward Access

```
Setup → Roles → Set Up Roles
```

Create a parent role `Sales Manager`. Assign your Admin or Manager account to this role. Place `Sales User` roles for Rahul and Priya directly underneath `Sales Manager`.

Result: Log in as the Sales Manager. Search for `ABC Opportunity`. The manager can **see and edit** Rahul's opportunity through the Role Hierarchy!

STEP 04

Create Public Group & Owner-Based Sharing Rule

```
Setup → Public Groups → New ("Sales Support") | Setup → Sharing Settings → Opportunity Sharing Rules
```

1. Create a Public Group labeled `Sales Support` and add users.
2. In Sharing Settings, scroll to *Opportunity Sharing Rules* → Click **New**:
   - **Rule Type:** Based on record owner
   - **Opportunities owned by:** *Role: Sales User*
   - **Share with:** *Public Group: Sales Support*
   - **Access Level:** *Read/Write*. Click **Save**.

STEP 05

Execute & Revoke Manual Sharing

```
Log in as Rahul ➔ ABC Opportunity ➔ Sharing Button ➔ Add Priya
```

1. Rahul clicks the **Sharing** button on `ABC Opportunity`. Adds **Priya** with **Read/Write** access. Save.
2. Log in as Priya ➔ Search `ABC Opportunity` ➔ Visible & Editable!
3. Rahul opens the Sharing modal and deletes Priya's share.
4. Log in as Priya ➔ Refresh record ➔ Access Denied (Insufficient Privileges)!

12. Key Takeaways & Architectural Summary

1. OWD is the Foundation

OWD sets baseline non-owner access. It is the only place in Salesforce where record access can be restricted. All subsequent layers can only open access.

2. Roles Open Upward

Role Hierarchy automatically rolls record access vertically upward to managers. It governs data visibility, not company HR org charts or CRUD permissions.

3. Rules Open Laterally

Sharing Rules open access horizontally to Public Groups and Roles based on ownership or criteria, bridging silos across different branches of the hierarchy.

4. Object + Record Dual Gates

To access a record, a user must pass **both gates**: Object-Level CRUD permission (Profile/Perm Set) AND Record-Level sharing (OWD/Sharing).

13. Next Episode Preview

📺 Coming Up in Episode 38: Troubleshooting Record Access & Sharing Calculations

Now that we have established the complete sharing architecture, what happens when a user complains: *"Why can't I see this record?"* or *"Why can someone see a record they shouldn't?"* In Episode 38, we learn how to troubleshoot access using the **Record Sharing Hierarchy tool**, inspect underlying sharing tables, and resolve complex real-world authorization issues!